Success & progress

A conversational idiom workbook: 4 phrases, each with a short conversation and four quick tasks. Do it online and check your answers, or print it and use the answer key at the end.

In this workbook

1. **game changer**: Something that completely changes a situation, usually for the better.
2. **hit a plateau**: When you hit a plateau, you stop making progress for a while.
3. **make a go of it**: To try hard to make something you have started become successful.
4. **turn the tables**: To reverse a situation so the other side is now in the weaker or stronger position.

How to use it: read the conversation out loud first, then do the four tasks. For the last task, answer out loud before you write, and try to use the phrase naturally.

game changer

Idiom | Level B2 | Casual

Something that completely changes a situation, usually for the better.

Tip: Say 'a game changer' or 'a real game changer' for something that makes a big difference; it's often followed by 'for' + the person or situation affected, and it's usually positive.

Amira: How's the new job going? Are you still driving for an hour each way?

Diego: No, that's the best part. They let us work from home three days a week now.

Amira: Three days? That's a big change.

Diego: Honestly, it's a game changer. I have time to cook and go running again.

Amira: I'm jealous. My office still wants us there every day.

1. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "a game changer" mean?

- ○ A. A new hobby that someone starts to enjoy
- ○ B. A rule that makes work more competitive
- ○ C. A small improvement that most people don't notice
- ○ D. Something that completely changes a situation, usually for the better

2. Fill the gap

Getting a dishwasher was a real _____ for our busy family; we finally have our evenings back.

3. Choose the best reply

Kofi: *I started using a language app on my commute, and my vocabulary has grown so much in two months.*

- ○ A. Oh no, you should game changer your habits right away.
- ○ B. Yes, I love playing games on my phone too, so I understand.
- ○ C. Wow, that sounds like a real game changer for your English!

4. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a tool, habit or piece of technology that made a big difference in your daily life.

_____

_____

_____

hit a plateau

Idiom | Level B2 | Neutral

When you hit a plateau, you stop making progress for a while.

Tip: Use it as 'hit a plateau' (or 'reach a plateau') about skills, results, or numbers; it is often followed by 'so' plus a change of plan, and the past tense is most common.

Olena: How's the Spanish going? You were doing so well a few months ago.

Diego: Honestly, I think I've hit a plateau. I know the same words every week.

Olena: Are you still doing the same app lessons every day?

Diego: Yes, the same ones. I just repeat them.

Olena: Maybe try talking to real people. That might get you moving again.

Diego: Good idea. There's a language café near my office on Thursdays.

5. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "hit a plateau" mean?

- ○ A. Diego has reached a very high level.
- ○ B. Diego has stopped improving for a while.
- ○ C. Diego has made a big mistake in his lessons.
- ○ D. Diego has decided to give up Spanish.

6. Fill the gap

After six weeks of steady weight loss, Amira _____, so she added a short walk after dinner.

7. Choose the best reply

Kofi: *I've been saving £200 a month, but my savings haven't grown for the last two months.*

- ○ A. Maybe the plateau hit you. You should celebrate.
- ○ B. Maybe you've hit a plateau. Is your spending creeping up?
- ○ C. Maybe you've hit a plateau. That's great, keep going up!

8. Your turn: speak

Tell me about a skill or habit you worked on where you stopped improving. What did you do about it?

make a go of it

Idiom | Level B2 | Neutral

To try hard to make something you have started become successful.

Tip: Use it as 'make a go of it' (or 'make a go of + noun') after you have already started something, like a business, a move or a relationship; it's often used with 'decide to' or 'want to'.

Olena: I heard you've been selling your candles at the weekend market.

Amira: Yes, it started as a hobby, but people keep coming back for more.

Olena: So are you going to keep it small?

Amira: No, I've decided to make a go of it. I'm cutting my hours at the office to give it a proper chance.

Olena: That's brave. Let me know if you need help with the website.

9. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does "make a go of it" mean?

- ○ A. To try hard to make the candle business succeed
- ○ B. To sell the business to someone else
- ○ C. To make candles as a way of relaxing
- ○ D. To leave the business and go somewhere else

10. Fill the gap

Kofi and his sister bought a small cafe last spring, and they're working long days to _____.

11. Choose the best reply

Ken: *I've moved to a new city for the job, but I'm still not sure I'll like it here.*

- ○ A. Yes, I always make a go of it when I'm feeling tired.
- ○ B. Don't worry, you can make a go of it before you leave tomorrow.
- ○ C. Give it time. You've come this far, so you may as well make a go of it.

12. Your turn: speak

Tell me about something you started and wanted to turn into something bigger.

_____

_____

_____

turn the tables

Idiom | Level B2 | Neutral

To reverse a situation so the other side is now in the weaker or stronger position.

Tip: Use it as a verb phrase: 'turn the tables on someone' or 'turn the tables' on its own, usually in the past tense when talking about a comeback or a role reversal.

Kofi: Did you hear about the quarter-final? Our team was down by twelve points at half-time.

Olena: Twelve? That sounds almost impossible to recover from.

Kofi: Right? But they changed their defence completely and turned the tables in the third quarter.

Olena: So did they actually win?

Kofi: By four points. The other team couldn't believe it.

13. What does it mean?

In this conversation, what does turned the tables mean?

- ○ A. Moved the furniture to a different part of the room
- ○ B. Changed the situation so they went from losing to winning
- ○ C. Played the same way for the whole game
- ○ D. Gave the other team a chance to rest and recover

14. Fill the gap

My manager used to question everything I did, but after I found a serious error in her report, I managed to _____ on her.

15. Choose the best reply

Amira: *I always lose to my brother at chess, but yesterday I finally beat him twice in a row!*

- ○ A. Wow, you really turned the tables on him!
- ○ B. Wow, you really turned the tables for him!
- ○ C. Wow, you should turn the tables before you play again!

16. Your turn: speak

Can you describe a time when a difficult situation suddenly changed in your favour?

_____

_____

_____

Answer key

game changer

1. D. Something that completely changes a situation, usually for the better
2. game changer
3. C. Wow, that sounds like a real game changer for your English!
4. Example: For me, a good pair of noise-cancelling headphones was a game changer. I used to struggle to concentrate in my busy flat, but now I can study for hours without getting distracted. It has honestly made my days much more productive.

hit a plateau

5. B. Diego has stopped improving for a while.
6. hit a plateau
7. B. Maybe you've hit a plateau. Is your spending creeping up?
8. Example: I started learning the guitar last year, and for a few months I improved quickly. Then I hit a plateau, and I kept playing the same easy songs. I fixed it by learning a harder piece each week, and now I'm moving forward again.

make a go of it

9. A. To try hard to make the candle business succeed
10. make a go of it
11. C. Give it time. You've come this far, so you may as well make a go of it.
12. Example: A few years ago I started a small language group with a couple of friends, just for fun. It grew quickly, so we decided to make a go of it and now we run weekly sessions online. It takes a lot of time, but I'm proud of how far it has come.

turn the tables

13. B. Changed the situation so they went from losing to winning
14. turn the tables
15. A. Wow, you really turned the tables on him!
16. Example: Last year I was running late for an important meeting and thought I'd made a terrible impression. But when I arrived, the client was also stuck in traffic, so I used the extra time to prepare, and I completely turned the tables. In the end, I gave one of my best presentations.